Non-Alignment was premised on the belief that formal alliances were destabilizing, and that Indian independence and autonomy would not benefit from allying with either the United States or the Soviet Union. Instead, a ‘third way’ was possible, particularly among newly decolonizing states. Other post-colonial states, including Burma, Ceylon, and Indonesia, initially shared this assessment and cooperated with India in this respect. In theory, Non-Alignment enabled India to derive benefits from both the US-led and Soviet-led blocs and gave India a natural leadership perch in the post-colonial world. Nehru did not intend it to be equated with isolationism and wanted it to be flexible, as he himself argued in the Constituent Assembly on 4 December 1947:

> We have proclaimed during the past year that we will not attach ourselves to any particular group. That has nothing to do with neutrality or passivity or anything else. If there is a big war there is no particular reason why we should jump into it. Nevertheless, it is a little difficult nowadays in world wars to be neutral. Any person with any knowledge of international affairs knows that. The point is not what will happen when there is a war. Are we going to proclaim to the world . . . that when war comes, we stand by Russia? . . . That shows to me an amazing ignorance of how foreign affairs can be conducted. We are not going to join a war if we can help it; and we are going to join the side which is to our interest when the time comes to make the choice. There the matter ends.
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> But talking about foreign policies, the House must remember that these are not just empty struggles on a chess-board. Behind them lie all manner of things. Ultimately, foreign policy is the outcome of economic policy, and until India has properly evolved her economic policy, her foreign policy will be rather vague, rather inchoate, and will be groping. [13]

Nonetheless, as with state planning, there was criticism and debate within the Indian government about Non-Alignment as it played out in practice. In 1950, Patel—concerned about Nehru advocating for better relations with Beijing after the Communist Revolution and invasion of Tibet—argued that ‘even though we regard ourselves as friends of China, the Chinese do not regard us as their friends’. [14] In a 1951 speech explaining his resignation from the cabinet, Ambedkar worried that Non-Alignment had unduly distanced India from potential partners: ‘The third matter which has given me cause . . . for actual anxiety and even worry, is the foreign policy of the